

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

END OF ONE PARTY DOMINANCE

MODULE-13



PUNJAB

- 1 In Punjab, the euphoria generated by the Rajiv Gandhi-Longowal accord proved to be a highly temporary phenomenon.
- 2 The sant's assassination was a harbinger of things to come, with a new generation of terrorists taking up the struggle for Khalistan.
- 3 The injuries caused by Operation Bluestar and the anti-Sikh riots in Delhi had brought many fresh recruits to the cause. So had the failure of the central government to honour its commitment to transfer Chandigarh to Punjab.
- 4 Militants were once more making their home in the Golden Temple. Statements in favour of Khalistan were being made by priests and, on occasion, by members of the ruling Akali Dal itself.



JAMMU & KASHMIR

- 1 In 1987 fresh elections were held to the Jammu and Kashmir assembly.
- 2 To fight them, Kashmiri politicians seeking autonomy from the centre – rather than dependence or subservience – formed an umbrella grouping named the Muslim United Front (MUF).
- 3 MUF workers were harassed by the administration; and the polls themselves were anything but free and fair. Although the National Conference–Congress alliance would probably have won anyway, their margin of victory was made much greater by the rigging of votes in their favour.
- 4 Even the Intelligence Bureau conceded that as many as thirteen seats were lost by the MUF owing to 'electoral malpractice'.
- 5 The way the 1987 elections were conducted led to deep disenchantment among political activists in Kashmir.



PAKISTAN ENTERING THE POLITICAL SCENE

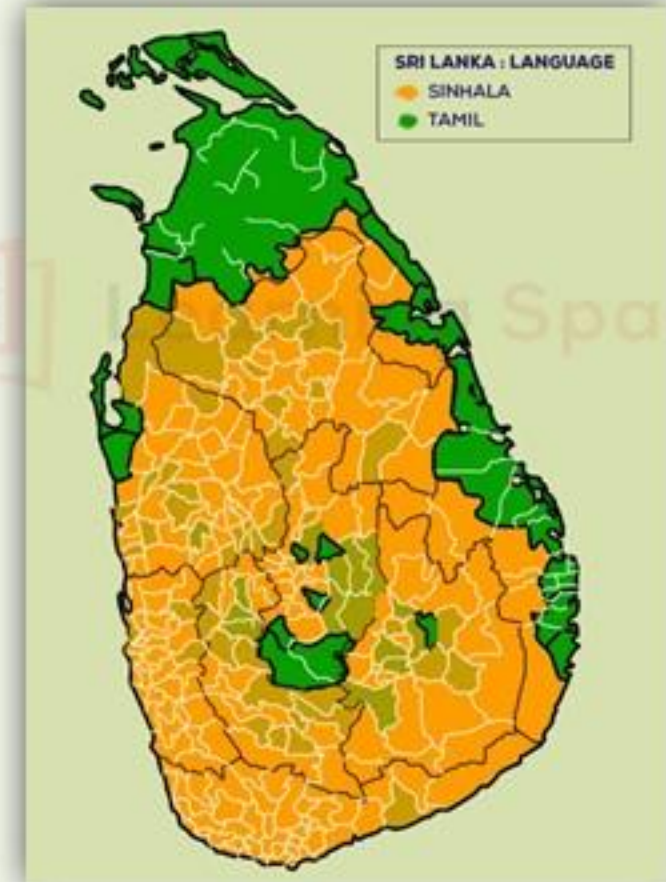
- 1 Despairing of being treated unfairly by New Delhi, they began looking to Pakistan for succour.
- 2 Groups of young men crossed the border, joining training camps run by the Pakistani army.
- 3 A year later they crossed back, to put into practice what they had learned.
- 4 In the spring of 1989, the Kashmir Valley was witness to a series of shootings, bomb blasts and grenade attacks.
- 5 This lovely valley was now home to 'Kalashnikovs, detonators, Molotov cocktails, gelatine fuses, mortars and masked militants'.
- 6 Ninety-seven separate incidents of violence were recorded in the first half of 1989, in which at least 52 people were killed and 250 injured.



SRI LANKA

- 1** Rajiv Gandhi embarked on an ambitious attempt to end ethnic strife in neighbouring Sri Lanka, which was caught in a bloody civil war between the Sinhala majority and the Tamil minority.
- 2** Sinhala was imposed as the sole 'official language' of the island nation.
- 3** The Tamils asked for parity for their own tongue and, when this was denied, took to the streets in protest.

Over the years, non-violent methods were thrown over in favour of armed struggle.





LIBERATION TIGERS OF TAMIL EELAM (LTTE)

- 1 Of the several Tamil resistance organizations, the most influential and powerful was the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE).
- 2 Led by a brutal fighter named Velupillai Prabhakaran, the LTTE had as its aim a separate nation, to be constituted from the north and east of the island, where the Tamils were in a majority.
- 3 LTTE fighters had long used the Indian state of Tamil Nadu as a safe haven. Their activities were actively helped by the state government,



INDIAN PEACEKEEPING FORCE

- 1** In the summer of 1987 Rajiv Gandhi was asked by the Sri Lankan President, J. R. Jayawardene to help mediate in the conflict.
- 2** Under an agreement signed between Colombo and New Delhi, an Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF) would be flown into the island. The Sri Lankan army would retreat to the barracks, and the LTTE militants persuaded – or forced – to disarm.
- 3** Sinhala nationalists saw it as an infringement of sovereignty, and the Tamils, who had always thought that India was on their side were disappointed.
- 4** When asked to surrender their arms, the LTTE insisted on a series of preconditions, including the release of all Tamil prisoners in government custody and a halt to Sinhala colonization in the east of the island. The LTTE headquarters in Jaffna was stormed and captured, but at an enormous cost.



THE ACCORD



Rajiv Gandhi and Jayewardene sign the India-Sri Lanka accord in Colombo in July 1987



'HEGEMON' IN SOUTH ASIA

- 1 Popular opinion turned decisively against the Indians, who were now seen as an occupying force.
- 2 The LTTE took to the jungles, from where they would snipe and harry the Indians.
- 3 They made particularly effective use of land mines, blowing up convoys of soldiers as they travelled on the roads.
- 4 From the summer of 1989 they began coming back, although the final pull-out was not accomplished until the spring of 1990.
- 5 More than 1,000 Indian soldiers had died in the conflict.

The decision to send in troops to Sri Lanka was consistent with India's growing perception of itself as the 'rightful regional hegemon in South Asia'. In demographic and economic terms it dominated the region, and it was now determined to express this dominance in terms of military preparedness as well.



INTERNATIONAL PLAYERS INVOLVED

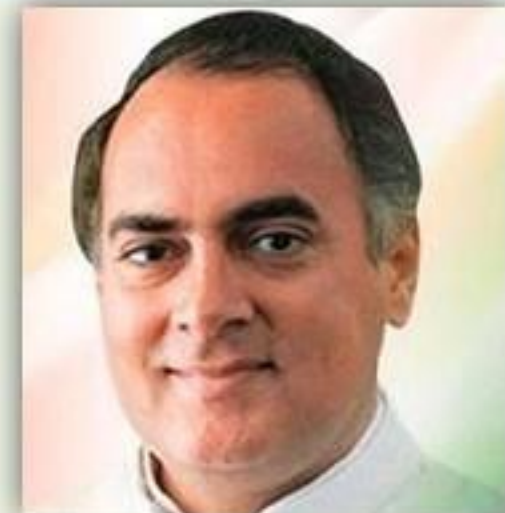
- 1** In March 1988, India tested its first surface-to-surface missile, capable of attacking targets up to a distance of a hundred miles away.
- 2** A year later it successfully tested a more sophisticated device, which could carry a load ten times more powerful and reach targets 1,500 miles away.
- 3** Indian missile scientists had taken their country into an exclusive club whose only other members were the United States, the Soviet Union, the United Kingdom, France, China and Israel.

These developments attracted apprehension in the smaller countries of South Asia.



RAJIV GANDHI'S INITIATIVES

- 1** In September 1988, he introduced a bill aimed at checking the freedom of the press. Under its terms, editors and proprietors could be sent to jail if they were guilty of 'scurrilous publication'. It prompted a collective protest by editors across the country and a walk-out in Parliament, and was eventually dropped.
- 2** In January 1989, Rajiv Gandhi visited China as an attempt to position himself as an international statesman. The border issue was not discussed. New Delhi ceded ground on Tibet, while Beijing for its part said it would not aid insurgents in India's north-east.
- 3**
 - In March 1989, Rajiv Gandhi reversed the outward-looking, growth-oriented economic policies of his first years in office.
 - In the last budget tabled by his government, he increased taxes on consumer durables and introduced fresh surcharges on air travel and luxury hotel bookings. At the same time, a new employment generation scheme was introduced for rural areas.



RAJIV GANDHI'S INITIATIVES

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- In the summer of 1989, the government launched a series of high profile events to celebrate the birth centenary of Jawaharlal Nehru.
- Seminars, photo exhibitions, TV quizzes, poetry festivals, musical concerts, even skating competitions, were held in Nehru's name, all paid for by the state.
- The real message that was being conveyed was that there was no better guardian of the nation than the Nehru family.

5

Rajiv Gandhi's government gave special emphasis to the then very nascent electronics and telecommunications industries.



RAJIV GANDHI'S ECONOMIC POLICIES

- 1** The government's first budget, introduced in March 1985, sought to remove some of the controls and checks in what was one of the most tightly regulated economies in the world.
- 2** The trade regime was liberalized, with duties reduced on a variety of import items and incentives provided for exporters.
- 3** The licensing regime was simplified, with key sectors such as machine tools, textiles, computers and drugs deregulated.



RAJIV GANDHI'S ECONOMIC POLICIES

4 Curbs on assets of individual companies were partially lifted, and rates of corporate and personal income tax reduced. These changes, it was argued, would result in increased production and greater competitiveness.

5 Left-wing intellectuals attacked the budget as pandering to the rich. Freeing the trade regime would make India excessively dependent on foreign capital, they argued.

6 There was an expanding market for consumer durables. New trades and businesses were opening all the time.

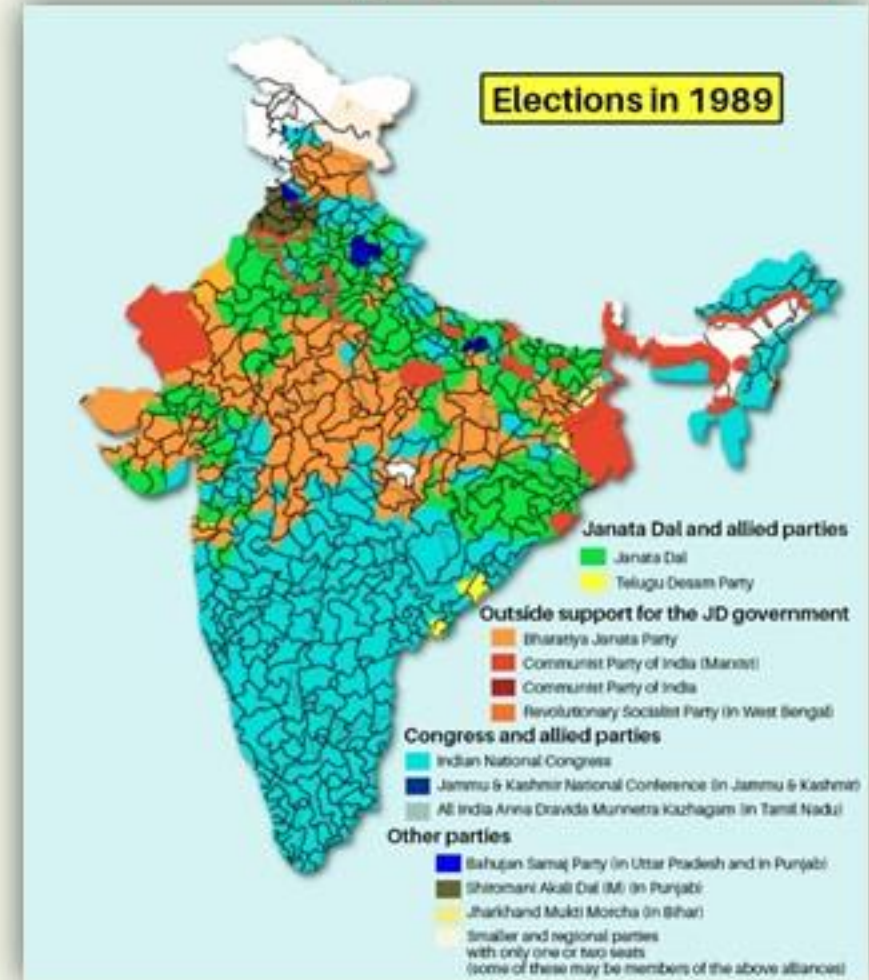


In his first year in office, Rajiv Gandhi had worked to resolve a series of ethnic conflicts – in Assam, in Mizoram, in the Punjab

ELECTIONS IN 1989

- 1 The elections, held in November 1989, were a body blow to the Congress Party.
- 2 They won only 197 seats, down more than 200 from their previous tally.
- 3 The Janata Dal won 142 seats, the BJP 86, and the left a few more than fifty.
- 4 At the 1989 elections in India, several regional parties very posed challenges to the Congress- Asom Gana Parishad had ruled in Assam, Akalis in Punjab and CPM in West Bengal and DMK in Tamil Nadu.
- 5 V. P. Singh was sworn in as head of a National Front government, with the left and the BJP choosing to support it from outside.

The general election of 1989 was the first in which no single party won a majority.



RAJIV GANDHI ASSASSINATED

1 In the middle of the Babri Masjid campaign Rajiv Gandhi was assassinated while speaking in a town in Tamil Nadu.

2 The assassin, who was also blown up by the bomb she was carrying, was later revealed to be a representative of the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam.



The killing was an act of vengeance, for the LTTE had not forgiven Rajiv Gandhi for sending troops against them in 1987.



NAGALAND

- 1** A group grew in Nagaland committed to the idea of an independent and sovereign Nagaland.
- 2** This was the National Socialist Council of Nagaland formed on January 31, 1980, led by Isaak Swu and T. Muivah.
- 3**
 - The NSCN had a solid core of several thousand well-trained fighters.
 - They operated from bases in Burma, making raids across the border and engaging the Indian army.
 - Within Nagaland the rebels commanded support.



CHALLENGES IN THE SETTLEMENT

There were **two** stumbling blocks:

- The rebels' insistence that a settlement had to be outside the framework of the Indian Constitution and their demand that parts of Manipur, Assam, and Arunachal Pradesh, where Naga tribes lived, be merged with the existing state of Nagaland into a Greater Nagalim.



**ISAK CHISHI SWU (LEFT) AND
THUINGALENG MUIVAH**

FOUNDED THE NSCN-IM

NEGOTIATIONS WITH GOVERNMENT

- 1** Prime Minister of India P V Narasimha Rao met Muivah, Swu and others in Paris on 15 June 1995.
- 2** Subsequently, Prime Minister H. D. Deve Gowda met them in Zurich on 3 February 1997, which was followed by meetings with officers in Geneva and Bangkok.
- 3** Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee met them in Paris on 30 September 1998.
- 4** The Government of India signed a ceasefire agreement with NSCN (IM) on 25 July 1997, which came into effect on 1 August 1997.

- 5** Over 80 rounds of talks between the two sides were held subsequently



GOVERNMENT DECISION

- 1** The Government of India said it would give the Nagas the fullest possible autonomy, but within the terms of the Indian Constitution.
- 2** The NSCN insisted that any solution must acknowledge Naga sovereignty, for – it claims – ‘Nagaland was never a part of India either by conquest by India or by consent of the Nagas’.
- 3** It also asks for the retention of a separate Naga army.



GOVERNMENT DECISION

- 4 The calls for a Greater Nagalim have been resisted by states who would have to cede territory to this new entity.
- 5 The Meities of Manipur have militantly opposed the proposal, claiming that their state had existed as an independent and integrated territory for over a thousand years.
- 6 In the mid-1990s, however, a collective of church groups and civil society organizations called the Naga HoHo persuaded the rebels and the government to declare a ceasefire. In 1997, the guns fell silent and the two sides began to talk.



NSCN FLAG



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